

A Married State



POEM TEXT

- 1 A married state affords but little ease;
- 2 The best of husbands are so hard to please:
- 3 This in wives' careful faces you may spell,
- 4 Though they dissemble their misfortunes well.
- 5 A virgin state is crowned with much content,
- 6 It's always happy as it's innocent:
- 7 No blustering husbands to create your fears,
- 8 No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,
- 9 No children's cries for to offend your ears,
- 10 Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers.
- 11 Thus are you freed from all the cares that do
- 12 Attend on matrimony, and a husband too.
- 13 Therefore, Madam, be advised by me:
- 14 Turn, turn apostate to love's levity.
- 15 Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,
- 16 There's no such thing as leading apes in hell.

What she sees does not persuade her that marriage is a good idea. In this short, rebellious poem, Katherine Philips's speaker makes the point that, for 17th-century British women, marriage is an oppressive institution that offers only a life of servitude and pain.

The married women this speaker has observed all seem to have "careful" (or careworn) faces. No wonder, considering that even the "best of husbands," to her eye, appear "hard to please"—and the worst are "blustering" bullies. For a woman, this speaker bluntly observes, marriage means a parade of troubles: dealing with an overbearing husband, suffering the terrible "pangs of childbirth," and listening to "children's cries" all day and night. The woman who marries doesn't even have time for the good of her own soul. The "worldly crosses" (or earthly burdens) of a "married state" mean she can't even say her prayers without "distract[ion]."

A single woman's life, on the other hand, is "crowned with much content," rewarded by peace and contentment. "Freed from all the cares" of matrimony, a woman can have a life free of "fears," "tears," and travails. The only drawback is that "wild nature"—her sexual urges—might try to persuade her that a husband is a good idea after all. This speaker's considered advice is to "suppress" such impulses for the good of one's own peace of mind.

Through this argument, the poem's speaker makes the quietly revolutionary suggestion that being an unmarried woman isn't a matter for shame (as might be implied by the old folk belief that women who die as spinsters have to "lead[] apes in hell" after they die, which the speaker pooh-poohs in the poem's final line). Rather, it's the only sensible choice for a woman who wants a life of "ease" and self-determination.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-16



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*A married state affords but little ease;
The best of husbands are so hard to please:
This in wives' careful faces you may spell,
Though they dissemble their misfortunes well.*

"A Married State" begins with a blunt statement of doubt in the value of marriage. Marriage is a way of life which, in the speaker's opinion, "affords but little ease": in other words, it doesn't offer much comfort or relaxation. Or, to be more



THEMES



MARRIAGE AND WOMEN'S OPPRESSION

The speaker of "A Married State" has closely observed the lives of the married women around her.

precise, it doesn't offer much comfort or relaxation to *wives*. Even the very "best of husbands," the speaker observes, are liable to be "hard to please." And that's if a wife is lucky: a finicky husband is the *most* a lady can hope for. Though wives may "dissemble their misfortunes well" (or try their best to disguise their sufferings), any reasonably alert observer can see the plain facts [metaphorically](#) "spell[ed]" out in "wives' careful faces" (that is, wives' careworn, troubled faces). Their pain is written in the lines of anxiety and suffering etched on their foreheads.

These lines indirectly introduce the reader to the speaker as much as to her subject matter. Clearly single herself, she's casting a wary eye over what life might be if she were to marry—and not finding much to like about the idea.

For a woman in 17th-century Britain (the context in which Katherine Philips wrote this poem), a hesitance to marry would be close to scandalous. Marriage or a dedicated religious life were the only altogether socially approved ways of life for a woman. Spinsterhood—staying unmarried—might be imagined as anything between burdensome (to a woman's family, who would have to support her all her life) and suspicious.

Frankly declaring that marriage looks pretty hard on women in a light, crisp, unflinching tone, this speaker thus comes across as bravely iconoclastic, not merely cynical (though there's certainly a dose of wry cynicism here, too).

Similarly iconoclastic is the fact that a woman is writing this poem at all. Women writers were still a rarity, not to say a novelty, in Philips's time. Her use of poetic form here helps to make a case that she's just as learned and astute a social critic as any man. She writes in brisk rhymed [couplets](#) of [iambic pentameter](#) (lines of five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "A **mar-** | ried **state** | affords | but **lit-** | tle **ease**")—a popular form that reflects a solid grounding in the history and practice of English poetry. (Her contemporaries, like [Robert Herrick](#), were using the same sorts of rhythms and rhymes in their own sometimes-scandalous verse.) This poem's brisk and jaunty form makes the speaker feel completely in control of her language and her point.

LINES 5-10

*A virgin state is crowned with much content,
It's always happy as it's innocent:
No blustering husbands to create your fears,
No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,
No children's cries for to offend your ears,
Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers.*

If a "married state" means nothing but cares and woes, the speaker goes on, then a "virgin state" (staying unmarried) means quite the contrary. Those women wise enough to avoid marriage enjoy lives "crowned with much content," a [metaphor](#) that suggests a kind of queenly power and self-possession goes

along with the simple "content" (or contentment) of singleness. "Innocent" of sex, such a state is also "happy"—and the speaker is here to tell her female readers exactly why.

Stay single, she says, and you'll have:

No blustering husbands to create your fears,
No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,
No children's cries for to offend your ears,
Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers.

The intense [parallelism](#) of these lines, with their echoing sentence structure, makes the speaker's case against marriage feel as catchy as an ad. No marriage? No fears, tears, or whining babies: easy as that! The changed [rhyme scheme](#) in this section, with four rhymes in a row rather than the usual [couplets](#), makes the passage sound even more emphatic.

And it's hard to argue with the drawbacks of marriage the speaker enumerates here. A "blustering husband" might be anything from overbearing to out-and-out violent, if he "create[s] your fears." The "pangs of childbirth," for a 17th-century woman living in an age before anesthesia and antibiotics, would be not just agonizing, but potentially lethal.

Perhaps there's a slightly lighter tone in the speaker's observation that children's cries might "offend your ears": *the screams of babies are just so trying, darling*. But in the very lightness of this line, there's also a certain daring. The casual observation that childrearing might perhaps be more annoying than rewarding for a woman remains taboo to this day.

The speaker's final point in favor of singlehood here is similarly quietly revolutionary. "Worldly crosses," everyday burdens, are (to her mind) lessened if one avoids marriage—and that leaves plenty of time for one's private "prayers," one's relationship with God.

More usually, one's crosses to bear in life—the burdens of trouble one simply can't avoid—were imagined as things that brought one closer to God. (The [Christian origins of the metaphor](#) make that point clear. Dealing patiently with suffering was meant to be a way of following and imitating Christ.) But to this speaker, the unnecessary sufferings of marriage are only going to get in the way of your soul's progress, keeping you from engaging seriously with your own spiritual life. Here more than ever, she suggests that a woman's independent self and soul have a serious value that's worth protecting.

LINES 11-12

*Thus are you freed from all the cares that do
Attend on matrimony, and a husband too.*

In lines 11-12, the speaker caps her argument against marriage with a pithy [zeugma](#):

Thus are you freed from all the cares that do
Attend on matrimony, and a husband too.

In other words: *if you avoid getting married, you'll be free from all the troubles inherent in marriage—and you'll be free from a husband, too.*

The zeugma here presents a husband as inherently as troublesome as any of the other burdens of a marriage. Leave aside the fears, tears, and offensive wailing of babies that marriage brings: a husband is *in himself* a burden, this phrasing suggests.

Once again, this is some pretty strong stuff for a 17th-century female writer. Presenting a husband as nothing more than a burden, an impediment, and a cross to bear, this poem's speaker flies in the face of a culture that saw finding a husband as nearly every woman's primary and central goal.

But perhaps it's worth noting, too, that staying free of a troublesome husband would have been a much more attractive option for those women who had a little money and a little social status. Women had few property rights of their own; indeed, they *became* the property of their husbands when they married. The course of action this speaker is proposing isn't one that would be easy or comfortable for every woman. Giving up on matrimony would involve having a lot of courage (and a lot of resources) to fall back on.

LINES 13-16

*Therefore, Madam, be advised by me:
Turn, turn apostate to love's levity.
Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,
There's no such thing as leading apes in hell.*

As the poem ends, the speaker caps her argument with some direct advice to any single woman who might happen to be reading. "Therefore, Madam," she says—using the polite title to mean ladies in general—"be advised by me."

Her final, powerful advice (emphasized by passionate [epizeuxis](#)) is to "turn, turn apostate to love's levity." An "apostate" is a person who rejects their former religion. In this vision, then, love is a kind of faith—but a faith of "levity," an unserious, insincere, and unreliable kind of belief. By extension, a belief in the value of one's own time, independence, and "ease" must be the truer faith.

This closing passage does, however, acknowledge that love (and not just conventionality or [social pressure](#)) might lead a woman to make the ill-advised decision to get married. The speaker admits as much when she counsels women to "suppress wild nature if she dare rebel." She understands that a woman's natural urges—her sex drive, in other words—might prompt her to make a choice that goes against her good sense. [Personifying](#) "wild nature" as a female figure here, the speaker might even suggest that every woman has to fight an internal battle against

herself, pushing back against that part of her that finds a man a tempting idea.

But in this vision, the part of a woman that wants to do the conventional thing—get married and have babies—is the "rebel[lious]" part, while the part of a woman who wants to stay single is the sage and sober part. This is a complete reversal of societal expectations for women in the period, a point that comes into sharp focus in the poem's closing line:

There's no such thing as leading apes in hell.

To the modern-day reader, this line might seem purely surreal. To Philips's original audience, however, it would have been a familiar [allusion](#) to the proverbial fate of unmarried women. (Shakespeare's spiky heroines [Beatrice](#) and [Katherine](#) make the same allusion.) Why, exactly, unmarried women were said to be punished in the afterlife by leading monkeys around is a question with several plausible answers. Perhaps the apes are meant to represent the men a woman led on in life or to be the [symbolic](#) manifestation of her unmarried sexual promiscuity. (More on that under the "Devices" section of this guide.) But exactly what the apes might mean here matters less than the fact that spinsterhood was, in the popular consciousness of Philips's time, an eternally punishable offense.

In pooh-poohing that idea, Philips's speaker also pooh-poohs an entire misogynist culture: briefly, pithily, wittily, and fearlessly.



POETIC DEVICES

PARALLELISM

"A Married State" uses [parallelism](#) to make its central argument—that women should stay single at all costs—in the most forceful terms. In the middle of the poem, Philips's speaker gives a no-nonsense list of some of the many things there are to enjoy about being an unmarried lady. Most of these pleasures are in fact the absence of pains. In a "virgin state," she explains, there are:

No blustering husbands to create your fears,
No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,
No children's cries for to offend your ears,
Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers.

The repeated sentence structure here (especially the intense [anaphora](#) on the word "No" in lines 7-9) gives these lines the catchy punch of an advertisement. No husband, no fear (and no tears, offensively loud shrieking, or distraction from the good of your own soul).

With this argument under her belt, the speaker thus counsels any women who happen to be listening:

Therefore, Madam, be advised by me:
Turn, turn apostate to love's levity.
Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,

These lines are driven by imperative verbs: "turn," "suppress." (That effect is strengthened even further in line 14 by the powerful [epizeuxis](#) of "turn, turn"). In these echoing commands, the speaker comes across as a rallying leader—*come on, girls, you can do it!*—and also perhaps as a desperate rescuer, aware she must fight against "wild nature" itself in urging women to give up on "love's levity."

Where Parallelism appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-10:** "No blustering husbands to create your fears, / No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears, / No children's cries for to offend your ears, / Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers."
- **Line 14:** "Turn, turn apostate"
- **Line 15:** "Suppress wild nature"

PERSONIFICATION

At the end of the poem, the speaker gives a nod to the fact that it's not necessarily the easiest thing in the world for women to give up on men and never marry. She does so by imagining women locked in a struggle with "wild nature," a force she [personifies](#) as a female figure itself. Nature, the speaker admits, might "rebel" against a lady's plans to stay single and might thus need to be "suppress[ed]." Women, in other words, might find themselves struggling with the more earthy, biological reasons for having a husband. To put it bluntly, the allure of sex (taboo outside marriage for 17th-century women) is a woman's greatest enemy if she wants to live a life of free and easy singlehood.

By casting "wild nature" as a woman here, Philips draws on a [long tradition](#) of presenting the embodiment of nature as female. But she also raises the interesting possibility that a woman who wishes to stay single might have to battle with *herself*, facing off against her own sexual nature.

What's more, the language of suppression and rebellion feels familiar from the earlier lines of the poem, in which the speaker describes what happens to women who *do* marry. Marry, and you'll get suppressed by a "blustering husband"; avoid marriage, and you might have to suppress the "wild nature" within you.

(Of course, one solution to this dilemma might be to seek out the company of people other than men—a possibility that some critics feel [may well have occurred](#) to Philips and her circle of intimate female literary friends.)

Where Personification appears in the poem:

- **Line 15:** "Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,"

ALLUSION

This poem's striking final line—"There's no such thing as leading apes in hell"—might seem purely surreal to a modern reader. But to Philips's 17th-century audience, this would be a familiar [allusion](#), a reference to the proverbial fate of unmarried women. (Readers who have spent some time with two of Shakespeare's sharpest heroines, [Katherine](#) and [Beatrice](#), may already have encountered this image.)

There's no single agreed-upon explanation for *why* this idea was proverbial. Perhaps the image is meant to be a fittingly [ironic](#) punishment (in [fine Dantean contrapasso style](#)) for women who led foolish men on without marrying any of them. Perhaps it's meant to suggest that women who don't marry are secretly as lustful as apes, scandalously satisfying their sexual desires outside of marriage—and thus deserve to be among the apes after their deaths. Or perhaps it has something to do with the not-particularly-complimentary-to-men idea that it's women's lot to take care of *some* number of apes, whether in this life or the next.

But the bigger idea that this allusion treats is the role of single women in Philips's world. The very fact that the leading-apes idea exists is evidence that the single women of Philips's era were believed to be a problem—such a problem that they deserved an afterlife comeuppance for their unmarried state. In rejecting the idea that single ladies end up in the middle of a simian fiesta in the afterlife, Philips's speaker is also rejecting the idea that women should be punished for making the sensible decision not to bind themselves to a "blustering husband."

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Line 16:** "There's no such thing as leading apes in hell."

METAPHOR

"A Married State" uses a few familiar [metaphors](#)—and a stronger, stranger one. To deal with the more commonplace metaphors first:

- Early in the poem, the speaker describes being able to "spell" (or read) how wives really feel about being married in their "careful faces" (that is, their nervous, careworn faces). It's not uncommon to describe guessing someone's emotions from their expressions as "reading" their faces. But the image of "spell[ing]" in particular does also nicely hint that the speaker might be able to read these poor wives' faces through the crisscrossing lines of suffering that are etched, like letters, on their foreheads.

- The life of a "virgin" or unmarried woman, by contrast, is "crowned with much content." Single life, here, becomes a queenly diadem, a metaphor that implies self-determination and personal power are two big advantages of remaining unmarried.
- Finally, the speaker mentions that being single means having "few worldly crosses to distract your prayers." This is a metaphor drawn from Christian tradition. Life's burdens and sufferings were said, in the 17th century as now, to be one's "[crosses to bear](#)." Here, interestingly, the speaker suggests that having fewer "worldly crosses" to deal with might be good for one's spiritual life. (The more usual idea was that patiently bearing one's crosses brought one closer to God.)

The poem's spiciest metaphor, however, arrives toward the end of the poem, when the speaker urges women to "turn, turn apostate to love's levity." To be an "apostate" is to be someone who rejects a religion they formerly followed. Here, then, love is a religion—but a deeply unserious one, an unreliable religion of "levity" (or incautious, heedless fickleness). This speaker feels urgently that the kind of love that leads to marriage with a man is a false god.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 3:** "This in wives' careful faces you may spell,"
- **Line 5:** "A virgin state is crowned with much content,"
- **Line 10:** "Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers."
- **Line 14:** "Turn, turn apostate to love's levity."



VOCABULARY

Affords (Line 1) - Offers, provides.

Careful (Line 3) - Burdened with cares, or worries and troubles.

Spell (Line 3) - Read. (The idea is that wives' troubles are written all over their faces.)

Dissemble their misfortunes (Line 4) - Try to hide the fact that they're suffering.

A virgin state (Line 5) - That is, the life of an unmarried woman.

Content (Line 5) - Contentment, simple happiness.

Blustering (Line 7) - The word "blustering" might here suggest both "bullying" and "yelling."

Pangs (Line 8) - Labor pains.

Extort your tears (Line 8) - Wrench tears of pain out of you.

Worldly crosses (Line 10) - Earthly troubles.

Apostate (Line 14) - An apostate (pronounced "uh-POSS-tate") is a person who turns against a religious creed. The speaker is advising her female readers to renounce the "religion" of love.

Levity (Line 14) - Inconstancy, fickleness, unreliability. (Romantic love with a man, in other words, cannot be counted on to provide lasting satisfaction.)

Wild nature (Line 15) - "Wild nature" here suggests sexual urges—the desires that might lead a woman to choose marriage over remaining single.

Leading apes in hell (Line 16) - This was the [proverbial fate](#) of women who died unmarried.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"A Married State" is written in one stanza: 16 brisk lines of [iambic](#) pentameter (lines of five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "A **mar-** | ried **state** | affords | but **lit-** | tle ease"). This is a crisp and witty poem, making its central point—that marriage, for women, is a fool's errand—with few words wasted.

The poem's bite-sized pithiness might help to support the speaker's point. It takes only four lines for Philips's speaker to outline a persuasive case for the pleasures of spinsterhood and against the drawbacks of a "married state." *It's as clear as day*, the poem's compactness seems to suggest: *why bother going on and on when it's so very obvious it's better for women to stay single?*

In its choice of [meter](#), its brevity, and its crisp rhymed [couplets](#), this poem fits right into the literary world around it. Readers might compare Philips's style here to the forms chosen by her fellow 17th-century writers like [Robert Herrick](#) and [Andrew Marvell](#). These poets used similar rhymes and rhythms in their witty, sexy poetry. But while Herrick and Marvell were [trying to talk women into bed](#), Philips was trying to talk women out of it.

METER

"A Married State" is written in [iambic](#) pentameter. That means that each of its lines uses five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm. Here's how that sounds in line 1:

A mar- | ried state | affords | but lit- | tle ease

Iambic pentameter is one of the most common rhythms in English-language metered poetry. Philips was choosing the go-to [meter](#) of 17th-century verse here, fitting in with contemporary literary culture even as she rebelled against contemporary sexual mores.

Like many poets writing in iambic pentameter, Philips plays with her rhythm a little, moving **stresses** around for extra emphasis. For instance, listen to line 14, in which the speaker gives some serious advice to her fellow women:

Turn, turn | apo- | state to | love's lev- | ity.

Twice in this line, Philips pushes two **stresses** together into a kind of metrical foot known as a [spondee](#), with a bold DUM-DUM rhythm. There's no mistaking the urgency in the speaker's voice when those powerful stresses hit.

RHYME SCHEME

"A Married State" is written in rhymed [couplets](#). That means that its rhymes travel in pairs:

AABBCC

...and so on. The effect is light, snappy, and funny: most of these couplets contain one complete thought, giving the paired lines a setup-punchline rhythm.

But in lines 7-10, the speaker doubles down on those couplets, with four rhymes in a row:

DDDD

Glance at the content of those lines, and you'll see why. This passage of the poem describes all the burdens of marriage that the wise woman avoids by staying single: mean husbands, agonizing labor pains, [wailing babies](#), and a general heap of burdens and irritations. The long chain of rhymes makes all these consequences feel like part of the same distasteful package. (Note that the final rhyme in this sequence, "prayers," sounds like a [slant rhyme](#) to the modern ear. But it might have matched "fears," "tears," and "ears" perfectly in a 17th-century English accent, in which vowels sounded a little different than they do today.)



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is a worldly-wise woman offering advice to other women. She's looked around her and noticed a few things about women's lives, and she feels confident in saying that women who stay single have it way better than women who get married. She describes seeing right through those wives who "dissemble their misfortunes" (or pretend they're not suffering): she can read the nasty truth in those poor women's "careful faces" (faces marked by worries).

Her confident voice reflects a piercing intelligence, a sharp wit, and a cheerful fearlessness in [pooh-poohing](#) traditional ideas about the pleasures of wifehood and motherhood. Stay single, she advises her fellow women, and you won't have to put up with squalling babies, agonizing labor pains, or bullying men. The only real problem of a "virgin state" is that you might have to "suppress wild nature"—that is, your natural sexual desire—if it tries to persuade you that a man sounds like a good idea after all.

In her iconoclasm and her droll tone, this speaker is at once a rebel and a woman of her times. Seventeenth-century England saw a flowering of women's voices in literature—with [some of those voices](#) saying [pretty revolutionary things](#). But such

opportunities to speak out were mostly open to women of the middle and upper classes (as Philips herself was), who were more likely to have the education and the leisure time for writing. Similarly, this speaker's plan to stay single forever would have been a lot easier to achieve for a woman with a little money and social status of her own. Independence, for a 17th-century woman, wouldn't have come cheap.



SETTING

Though the poem doesn't explicitly describe a setting, readers can gather that it's a poem of Philips's own time and place: 17th-century Britain. Women of this era didn't have many options. For women of the upper and middle classes (like Philips), marriage or joining a religious order were pretty much the only respectable life choices. If one were lucky enough to belong to a well-to-do family, one could also stay single and live with one's relatives for one's whole life, often becoming the *de facto* caretaker of the household. To modern readers, it's not the most inspiring range of possibilities.

But to this poem's speaker—presumably an educated and relatively well-off person, as revealed by the fact that she's writing a poem at all—staying single is by far the best of any woman's limited options. Marriage, to this speaker, means being trapped under a domineering husband's thumb, surrounded by screaming babies, with no time for your own thoughts. The only real advantage is getting to have sex in a socially acceptable context—and that, for this canny speaker, is nowhere near a good enough compensation for all the drawbacks.

These things, of course, might be said of the "married state" for many heterosexual women today, too. Perhaps more revealing of this poem's particular setting is the speaker's reminder that the "pangs of childbirth" are a serious consideration in deciding whether or not to marry. Pre-anesthesia, those pangs were nothing to be sneezed at. Childbirth in 17th-century Britain was often not merely painful for the mother, but lethal: countless women and babies died in labor. Who could blame this speaker for wanting none of it?



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

During her lifetime, Katherine Philips (1631-1664) was better known as "the Matchless Orinda"—her pen name as the leader of a mostly-female correspondence circle and literary salon, the Society of Friendship. As Orinda, Philips was one of the most celebrated and learned writers of her time, in an era in which women writers were far from common (though also [not unheard of](#), and often well-respected). A translator of French plays and a prolific writer of verse, she became particularly

famous for the intensely emotive poetry she wrote to her female friends—poetry which has led some critics to hail her as an early lesbian writer.

Philips might arguably be called a Cavalier poet: one of those life-loving, witty writers who supported King Charles I (and the restoration of King Charles II) at the time of the English Civil War. Like her contemporaries [Robert Herrick](#) and [Richard Lovelace](#), she wrote verse in support of the deposed Charles I—a daring thing to do at the time, not only because women were not supposed to involve themselves so actively in politics, but because her own husband's political beliefs differed from hers.

Philips was also influenced by Metaphysical poets like her friend Henry Vaughan and the great poet-clergyman [John Donne](#) (whose elaborate [conceits](#) she sometimes reworked in her own poetry). Like [many of those poets](#), Philips didn't actively seek publication during her lifetime (which would have been considered rather gauche). In fact, she was mortified when an unauthorized collection of her work appeared. But after her death from smallpox at the age of only 33, "A Married State" (among other poems) was published officially in the posthumous volume *Poems by the Most Deservedly Admired Mrs Katherine Philips, the Matchless Orinda* (1667). Though Philips is relatively obscure today, her work remained influential and respected for many years; the great 19th-century Romantic poet [John Keats](#) was only [one of her admirers](#).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Philips comes out strongly against marriage in this poem, a fact which has led some critics to wonder whether she composed it before or after her marriage at age 16 to James Philips, a man many years her senior. While Philips doesn't have anything good to say about husbands here, her real-life marriage seems likely to have been a comparatively happy and egalitarian one for the era. In some of her poetry, she refers to her husband affectionately (or teasingly) as "Antenor," an elderly counselor in Homer's *Iliad*. And she was quite comfortable maintaining differing political beliefs to her husband's, even in a fraught political era: he was a Parliamentarian, she a Royalist.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Brief Biography](#) — Read the Poetry Foundation's short biography of Philips. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/katherine-philips>)
- [Women Writers in the 17th Century](#) — Read about the Folger Shakespeare Library's exhibit on the many women writers who rose to fame in and around Philips's time. (https://folgerpedia.folger.edu/Shakespeare%27s_Sisters:_Voices_of_English_and_European_V)
- [The Matchless Orinda](#) — Read a short article that discusses Philips's place in the "Society of Friendship," a group of women writers. As leader of this group, she was given the pen name "The Matchless Orinda"—and wrote poems for her female friends that some modern critics see as early expressions of lesbian love. (<https://rcahmw.gov.uk/the-matchless-orinda-katherine-philips-1632-1664-a-queer-welsh-story/>)
- [A Portrait of Philips](#) — Take a look at an engraved portrait of Philips from her posthumously published collection of poetry. (Notice that this portrait presents her as a classical statue bust, honoring her by putting her in the lineage of Greek and Roman writers.) (<https://pressbooks.pub/earlybritishlit/chapter/katherine-philips-selected-poems/>)



HOW TO CITE

MLA

Nelson, Kristin. "A Married State." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 19 Aug 2025. Web. 2 Sep 2025.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Nelson, Kristin. "A Married State." LitCharts LLC, August 19, 2025. Retrieved September 2, 2025. <https://www.litcharts.com/poetry/katherine-philips/a-married-state>.